

Emotional Regulation

A practical guide for a capable, articulate autistic adult — for the times when feelings build up before you notice them.

Why this can catch you off guard

Being “high-functioning” means you can mask, reason and hold things together in the moment — which also means distress can grow quietly in the background while your thinking mind is busy coping. Many autistic people experience **interoception** differently: the internal signals that say “*I am getting overwhelmed*” arrive faint, late, or not at all. So the first time you consciously notice something is wrong, you may already be near the edge. This is not a personal failing or lack of willpower — it is a difference in how your nervous system reports its own state.

The build-up usually has stages

1. **Baseline (Green)** — calm, flexible, curious.
2. **Rumbling (Amber)** — small irritations stack up; you feel “off” but can’t always name it.
3. **Edge (Orange)** — less patience, urge to leave, snappy, foggy.
4. **Crisis (Red)** — meltdown or shutdown; logic goes offline.
5. **Recovery** — drained, fragile, easily re-triggered for hours.

Two ways it can show up

Meltdown — an outward overflow: irritation, raised voice, tears, pacing, needing to escape, intense reaction to a “small” trigger.

Shutdown — an inward collapse: going quiet and flat, words won’t form, withdrawing, staring, feeling numb or far away. Easy to mistake for “being fine” or just tired — it isn’t.

Early signs you may be missing

Because the emotion itself can be hard to feel, it often helps to watch for **body and behaviour clues** instead. These tend to appear *before* you consciously feel upset:

- Tight jaw, shoulders, chest; clenched hands; shallow breathing
- Sudden need for silence, dark, or to be alone
- Sounds, light, textures or touch feel “too loud” all at once
- Re-reading the same line; thoughts feel sticky or slow
- Snapping at people you care about over something minor
- Stimming more (rocking, tapping, pacing) or going very still
- A flat “I just need to go” urge with no clear reason
- Appetite, words, or humour quietly switching off

One sentence to keep

“If my body feels tense, my patience is thin, or the world feels too loud — I may be dysregulating, even if I can’t feel the emotion yet. That is my cue to act early, not to push harder.”

Handling It — What Actually Helps

Three timeframes: catch it early, ride out the peak, and recover well. Pick one or two ideas from each and make them your defaults.

In the moment (Amber / Orange)

The goal is not to “calm down and carry on” — it is to **lower the load** so your nervous system has less to process.

- **Reduce input first.** Leave the room, dim lights, headphones / earplugs, sunglasses, fewer people. Sensory load is usually the real driver.
- **Slow the breath out.** Breathe in for 4, out for 6–8. A longer exhale tells the body it is safe.
- **Use your body.** Press feet into the floor, push against a wall, hold something cold or weighted, walk. Movement discharges the build-up.
- **Drop demands.** Postpone the decision, conversation or task. “I’ll come back to this in 20 minutes” is a complete strategy.
- **One channel only.** Pick a single, low-demand input (a known song, a repetitive task, a special interest) instead of many.

Prevention (building your Green baseline)

- **Budget your energy.** Masking, socialising and noise all cost “spoons.” Plan recovery time *before* you run out, not after.
- **Protect the basics.** Sleep, food, hydration and unstructured downtime are regulation, not luxuries.
- **Schedule decompression.** Quiet gaps after meetings, shops, or social events — deliberately, in the calendar.
- **Know your triggers.** Track what precedes hard days (noise, heat, change of plan, hunger, too many transitions) so you can see patterns.

Recovering afterwards

After a meltdown or shutdown you are **depleted and easily re-triggered**. Treat it like recovering from illness:

- Low light, low noise, low demand for a while
- No big decisions or hard talks yet
- Gentle, familiar comfort — food, routine, a special interest
- Self-kindness: it was overload, not bad character

Noticing it sooner

Build the awareness you can’t always feel in real time:

- Keep a simple log: *energy / sleep / what happened*
- Rate yourself Green–Amber–Orange–Red a few times a day
- Set phone check-ins: “How is my body right now?”
- Ask a trusted person to gently flag when you seem ‘off’

Telling the people around you

You don’t have to explain in the moment — agree a signal in advance. For example: “*If I say I need a reset, it means I’m overloaded and will be back in 20 minutes — it isn’t about you.*” Naming it ahead of time removes the pressure to perform calm.

When to reach for more support

If meltdowns or shutdowns are frequent, getting more intense, affecting work or relationships, or you notice thoughts of not wanting to be here — please talk to your GP or an autism-informed therapist (OT for sensory and interoception work, or approaches like CBT/DBT adapted for autistic adults). Needing support is sensible maintenance, not weakness. In a crisis in the UK, call **111**, or **Samaritans on 116 123**, any time.